Twilight: Los Angeles, 1992

By Anna Deavere Smith

INTRODUCTION

The 1992 Los Angeles riots, also known as the Rodney King uprising or the Rodney King riots, were sparked on April 29, 1992 when a predominately white jury acquitted four police officers accused in the videotaped beating of black motorist Rodney King when he resisted arrest following a high-speed car chase. Thousands of blacks in the Los Angeles area joined in what is known as a race riot involving acts of law-breaking including looting, assault, arson and murder. In all, 53 people died during the riots. Anna Deavere Smith offers a stark insight into the complex and pressing social, economic, and political issues that fueled the flames in the wake of the Rodney King verdict by dramatizing her interviews with a racially diverse population at the scene of the riots. Travel back to me now to . . . . . Twilight: Los Angeles, 1992 by Anna Deavere Smith.

Elvira Evers, General Worker and Cashier, Canteen Corporation

With a baby bottle in her hand. At her kitchen table. A black woman from Panama in her forties. Children can be heard off stage. A Panamanian accent. She has a gold front tooth.

So it was like a carnival out there
and I say
to my friend Frances
"Frances, you see this?"
and she said, "Girl, you should see
that
it's getting worst."
And I say, "Girl, let me take my butt
up there before something happen."
And, um,
when somebody throw a bottle
and I just. . .
then I felt
like moist,
and it was like a tingling sensation, right?
And I didn't like this,
and it was like itchin',
and I say, "Frances, I'm bleedin'."
And she walk with me to her house.
And she say, "Lift up your gown, let me see."
She say, "Elvira, it's a bullet!"
I say, "What?"

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I say, "I didn't heard nothin'."
She say, "Yes, but it's a bullet."
She say, "Lay down there. Let me call St. Francis and tell them that you been shot and to send an ambulance."
And she say,
"Why you?
You don't mess with none of those people.
Why they have to shoot you?"
So Frances say the ambulance be here in fifteen minutes.
I say, "Frances,
I cannot wait that."
I say,
"I'm goin'!"
So I told my oldest son, I say,
"Amant, take care your brothers.
I be right back."
Well, by this time he was standing there, he was crying,
all of them was crying.
What I did for them not to see the blood
I took the gown and I cover it
and I didn't cry.
That way they didn't get nervous.
And I get in the car.
I was goin' to drive.
Frances say, "What you doin'?"
I said, "I'm drivin'."
She say, "No, you're not!"
And we take all the back streets,
and she was so supportive,
because she say, "You all right?
You feel cold?
You feel dizzy?
The baby move?"
She say, "You nervous?"
I say, "No, I'm not nervous, I'm just worried about the baby."
I say, "I don't want to lose this baby."
She say, "Elvira, everything will be all right." She say, "Just pray." So there was a lot of cars, we had to be blowing the horn.
So finally we get to St. Francis
and Frances told the front-desk office, she say,
"She been shot!"
And they say, "What she doin' walkin'?"
And I say, "I feel all right."
Everybody stop doin' what they was doin'
and they took me to the room
and put the monitor to see if the baby was fine
and they find the baby heartbeat,
and as long as I heard the baby heartbeat I calmed down,

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long as I knew whoever it is, boy or girl, it's all right,
and
matter of fact, my doctor, Thomas, he was there
at
the emergency room.
What a coincidence, right?
I was just lookin' for that familiar face,
and soon as I saw him
I say, "Well, I'm all right now."
Right?
So he bring me this other doctor and then told me,
"Elvira, we don't know how deep is the bullet.
We don't know where it went. We gonna operate on
you.
But since that we gonna operate we gonna take the baby out
and you don't have to
go through all of that."
They say, "Do you understand
what we're saying?"
I say, "Yeah!"
And they say, "Okay, sign here."
And I remember them preparing me
and I don't remember anything else.
Nella!
No.
(Turns to the side and admonishes the child)
She likes company.
And in the background
I remember Dr. Thomas say, "You have a six-pound-twelve-ounce little girl. "
He told me how much she weigh and her length
and he
say, "Um,
she born,
she had the bullet in her elbow,
but when we remove. . .
when we dean her up
we find out that the bullet was still between two joints,
so we did operate on her and your daughter is fine
and you are fine."
(Sound of a little child saying "Mommy")
Nella!
She wants to show the baby
Jessica.
Bring the baby.
(She laughs)
Yes,
yes.

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We don't like to keep the girls without earrings, we like the little girls
to look like girls from little.
I pierce hers.
When I get out on Monday,
by Wednesday I did it,
so by Monday she was five days,
she was seven days,
and I
pierced her ears,
and the red band is just like for evil eyes.
We really believe in Panama. . .
in English I can't explain too well.
And her doctor, he told,
he explain to me
that the bullet
destroyed the placenta
and
went through me
and she caught in her arms.
(Here you can hear the baby making noise, and a bell rings) If she didn't caught it in her arm,
me and her would be dead.
See?
So it's like
open your eyes,
watch what is goin' on.

Mrs. Young-Soon Han, Former Liquor Store Owner (Korean)

When I was in Korea
I used to watch many luxurious, Hollywood-lifestyle movies; I never saw any poor men, any black,
maybe one housemaid.
Until last year
I believed America is the best.
I still believe it.
I don't deny that now
because I'm victim,
but
as
the year ends in '92
and we were still in turmoil
and having all the financial problems
and mental problems.
Then a couple months ago
I really realized that

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Korean immigrants were left out
from this
society and we were nothing.
What is our right?
Is it because we are Korean?
Is it because we have no politicians?
Is it because we don't
speak good English?
Why?
Why do we have to be left out?
(She is hitting her hand on the coffee table)
We are not qualified to have medical treatment. We are not qualified to get, uh,
food stamps
(She hits the table once)
not GR
(Hits the table once)
no welfare.
(Hits the table once)
Anything.
Many Afro-Americans
(Two quick hits)
who never worked,
(One hit)
they get
at least minimum amount
(One hit)
of money
(One hit)
to survive.
(One hit)
We don't get any.
(Large hit with full hand spread) Because we have a car
(One hit)
and we have a house.
(pause six seconds)
And we are high taxpayers. *(One hit. Pause fourteen seconds)* Where do I finda [sic]
justice?
Okay, black people
probably
believe they won
by the trial?
Even some complains only half right.
Justice was there.
But I watched the television
that Sunday morning,
early morning as they started.
I started watch it all day.

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They were having party and then they celebrated,
all of South Central,
all the churches.
They finally found that justice exists
in this sodety.
Then where is the victims' rights?
They got their rights
by destroying innocent Korean merchants.
They have a lot of respect,
as I do,
for
Dr. Martin King?
He is the only model for black community.
I don't care Jesse Jackson.
But
he was the model
of nonviolence.
Nonviolence?
They like to have hiseh [sic] spirits.
What about last year?
They destroyed innocent people.
(pause five seconds)
And I wonder if that is really justice
(And a very soft" ah" after "justice," like "justiceah," but very quick) to get their rights
in this way.
(pause thirteen seconds)
I waseh swallowing the bitternesseh,
sitting here alone and watching them.
They became all hilarious
(pause three seconds)
and, uh,
in a way, I was happy for them
and I felt glad for them.
At least they got something back, you know.
Just let's forget Korean victims or other victims
who are destroyed by them.
They have fought
for their rights
(One hit simultaneous with the word "rights")
over two centuries
(One hit simultaneous with" centuries")
and I have a lot of sympathy and understanding for them. Because of their effort and sacrificing,
other minorities, like Hispanic
or Asians,
maybe we have to suffer more
by mainstream,

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you know.
That's why I understand,
and then
I like to be part of their
'joyment.
But.. .
that's why I had mixed feeling
as soon as I heard the verdict.
I wish I could
live together
with eh [sic] blacks,
but after the riots
there were too much differences.
The fire is still there
how do you call it?
igni. . .
igniting fire.
(She says a Korean word, "Dashi yun gi ga nuh")
It canuh
burst out anytime.

Twilight Bey, Organizer of Gang Truce

So a lot of times when I've brought up ideas to my homeboys, they say, "Twilight,
that's before your time,
that's something you can't do now."
When I talked about the truce back in 1988,
that was something they considered before its time,
yet in 1992
we made it
realistic.
So to me it's like I'm stuck in limbo,
like the sun is stuck between night and day
in the twilight hours.
You know,
I'm in an area not many people exist.
Nighttime to me
is like a lack of sun,
and I won't affiliate
darkness with anything negative.
I affiliate
darkness with what was first,
because it was first,
and then relative to my complexion.
I am a dark individual,
and with me stuck in limbo,

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I see darkness as myself.
I see the light as knowledge and the wisdom of the world and
understanding others,
and in order for me to be a, to be a true human being,
I can't forever dwell in darkness,
I can't forever dwell in the idea,
just identifying with people like me and understanding me and mine. So twilight
is
that time
between day and night,
limbo;
I call it limbo.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anna Deavere Smith
ISBN: 978-0385473767
Publisher: Anchor Books
Date (Month/Year): March 1994

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier

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